were the major social changes taking place during this period. In pre-industrial society, over 80% of people lived in rural areas. As the migration from the countryside began to intensify, small towns became large cities. The city of London grew from a population of two million in 1840 to five million in forty years.

Manchester's cool climate was ideal for textile production. Further it was situated close to the port of Liverpool and the coalfields of Lancashire. Manchester became the textile capital of the world, drawing huge numbers of migrants to the city. In 1771, Manchester was a sleepy town of 22,000 people. Over the next fifty years, its population exploded and reached upto 180,000.

Socio-economic Consequences

While the peasants were pauperized and the working class suffered, the middle class became wealthy by investing capital in trade and industry. The governments of the day were influenced by them. All legislations safeguarded their interests. Labourers were not permitted to form trade unions. It was under these circumstances that Socialism as a new ideology was born in Europe. Karl Marx advocated scientific socialism for the protection of the working class from the exploitative policies of the capitalist class. By the latter half of the nineteenth century there were strong working class movements all over western Europe which demanded economic as well as political rights.

Labour Movement

The Reform Bill of 1832 granted voting rights only to the propertied middle class. Frustrated by this, the working class in a large gathering prepared a charter of demands and obtained signatures from millions of fellow workers. The charter was presented to the House of Commons (the English Lower house in the Parliament, England). Known as Chartism, this working class movement was active between 1836 and 1848. The Chartists called for voting rights to every man over twenty-one years of age, secret ballot (voting), abolition of property qualification for members of the parliament, annual parliamentary elections and equal representation.

10.3 Spread of Industrial Revolution

Industrial Revolution in France

France did not possess as much natural resources as England. The political instability caused by the French Revolution and the prolonged Napoleonic Wars wrecked the country. Many of those French businessmen who had sought refuge in Britain during the Revolution, on their return to France after Napoleonic Wars, used British technology. This helped to accomplish industrial revolution in their country. The adoption of British-made spindles led to a two-fold increase in French textile production during 1830-1860.

The Francois de Wendel family brought British technology to Lorraine. The family introduced steam engine in coal mining and puddling kilns for iron smelting. By the 1860s the de Wendel family employed over 10,000 workers. By diversifying its business, it entered other heavy industries such as railroad construction and shipbuilding.


Francois de Wendel

The town of Mulhouse in the province of Alsace rose to prominence for its dyes that brought many designers there. From this foundation, Mulhouse diversified into the growing heavy industry of the region and became prominent as a maker of machines. Saint-Chamond saw developments in iron production. In 1820, the British technology of refining cast iron began to be used in this town.

In 1832, the first French railroad, St. Etienne–Andrezieux line was opened. Numerous railroad lines followed. By the end of the nineteenth

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